

China shows its IMO hand

送信者: POLITICO Pro Morning Mobility Europe 受信日時: 2026-08-31 14:08

【要点】

- ・ 中国がIMOの脱炭素化枠組みに関する具体的な提案を提示し、両派の間で妥協点を模索する柔軟なアプローチを主張している。
- ・ EUは共通の交渉立場で合意した一方、米国やサウジアラビア、ロシアなどは枠組みの大幅な変更を求めており、利害関係者間の対立が続いている。
- ・ 中国の提案では船舶の温室効果ガス削減計算方法を拡大し、岸電力や風力・太陽光発電、船上炭素回収なども考慮に入れることを求めている。
- ・ EUの委員会は2035年の自動車メーカーの排出目標設定について意見が分かれており、ドイツは電気自動車インセンティブプログラムに地域産業要件を含める調整を予定している。

【メール原文】

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By MARTINA SAPIO

with JORDYN DAHL

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SNEAK PEEK

— China is finally showing its hand on the IMO's contested shipping decarbonization framework, proposing several changes ahead of climate negotiations restarting Tuesday.

—The ENVI Committee is divided over what emission target automakers should reach in 2035, according to an analysis of the committee's amendments.

— Germany is going to adjust its electric vehicle incentive program to include local content requirements.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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INTRODUCING SURGE: POLITICO is launching a new daily global newsletter tracking how the worldwide explosion in electricity and power demand is reshaping the intersection of politics, policymaking and industry across North America and Europe. Think the AI electricity crunch and data centers, transmission bottlenecks, nuclear expansion, affordability, permitting and infrastructure fights, EV

politics and grid reliability, or the fallout of the global push to electrify as an alternative to fossil fuels.

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DRIVING THE DAY

SCOOP: CHINA SHOWS ITS IMO HAND: After months of holding back from laying out a detailed position on the contested Net-Zero Framework, China has proposed concrete changes to the rules just as IMO climate negotiations resume Tuesday, according to a nonpublic submission seen by POLITICO. Beijing stops short of joining either side of the polarized debate, instead calling for enough flexibility to accommodate competing approaches and find a global compromise.

Battle lines drawn: The intervention comes after EU countries — including Greece, despite fierce opposition from its powerful shipping industry — agreed a common negotiating position, while the U.S., Saudi Arabia, Russia, Panama, Liberia and others have pushed for substantial changes. The current proposed framework would progressively tighten ships' greenhouse gas intensity targets, with vessels that fall short facing compliance costs and money flowing through to an IMO Net-Zero Fund.

Beijing's pitch: China says the framework should remain "sufficiently broad and inclusive" to accommodate different approaches that could emerge during negotiations. Its proposed amendments would broaden the way ships calculate their greenhouse gas intensity, including potentially accounting for shore power, wind and solar energy and carbon captured onboard.

Follow the money: Beijing also wants to leave the future of the IMO's fund more open. Its amendments replace references to a Net-Zero "Fund" with the bracketed "[Fund] [Facility]", explicitly avoiding a decision for now on how it's structured, governed and run. China would also replace prescribed annual financial rewards for zero- and near-zero-emission fuels with broader "incentive measures," potentially including both financial support and more favorable treatment in emissions calculations.

U.S. engaging? Washington remains firmly opposed to the framework in its current form, but there are signs of openness to debate over what could replace it. U.S. Federal Maritime Commissioner Laura DiBella argued in August that a workable global fuel standard could provide the long-term certainty that investors need, while insisting that targets must reflect the actual affordability, availability and scalability of fuels.

LNG sticking point: DiBella's intervention also underlines one of the major divides heading into London. She wants LNG and bio-LNG explicitly recognized as transition fuels, arguing that existing infrastructure and growing supply could make them a realistic part of shipping's decarbonization.

Tuesday test: With the EU seeking to preserve its common line and opponents pushing for greater flexibility, China's willingness to finally put detailed amendments on the table could make it an important player in determining whether negotiators can find common ground this week.

CARS

ENVI COMMITTEE DIVIDED OVER CO2 STANDARDS: Even within the same party, MEPs in the ENVI Committee are divided over what emission targets automakers should reach in 2035. The European People's Party campaigned on overturning the 2035 de facto combustion engine ban, but the group's lawmakers in ENVI are split on what the target should be. As promised, Jordyn read through the 981 amendments to analyze where consensus is building (or not). She is accepting thanks in the form of coffee or donations to the seeing-eye dog she'll now inevitably need.

Recap: The European Commission proposed changing the 2035 law by lowering the emissions reduction target from 100 percent to 90 percent, so long as automakers offset the additional emissions through made-in-EU green steel and alternative fuels. Catch up here on what the TRAN committee wants.

Where they stand: Italian MEP Massimiliano Salini is the lead negotiator for Parliament and a member of the EPP. His draft report goes further than the Commission's proposed 90 percent, arguing for an effective 73 percent target by setting a base of 80 percent and 17 percent in offsets like fuels and green steel. Two EPP ENVI members — Flavio Tosi and Letizia Moratti — also want a baseline 80 percent target.

Not convinced: The EPP's Peter Liese and Dennis Radtke want to keep the Commission's proposed 90 percent target with low-carbon steel, is made in the EU, available as an offset for automakers. Fellow EPP member Alexander Bernhuber similarly wants 90 percent emission reduction, but more flexible offsets. A separate camp of eight EPP MEPs agree the sector needs more flexibility but say electric vehicles need to be scaled up to reduce fossil fuel dependency, delaying the combustion engine ban to 2045.

Let the negotiations begin: The split in the party makes pushing through Salini's proposal a tougher bet. While the European Conservatives and Reformists and the Patriots are set on further weakening the emission target, Renew is also divided over what the target should be, with some aligned with ECR and others wanting a target of 93 percent.

Local content catching on: One of the new regulations in the package would give supercredits to automakers that produce small EVs produced in the EU. While the parties disagreed over the amount of credits and what size car should qualify, nearly all of the amendments kept local content requirements. The Patriots want credits to be given to any vehicle that is made in Europe.

What's in a name: The European Conservatives and Reformists, along with some the far-right Patriots and some EPP MEPs, want vehicles running on alternative fuels to be classified as zero-emission vehicles and thus count toward the emission reduction target. The Socialists and Democrats, some Renew MEPs and a camp of EPP members argue the fuels should be used for harder-to-decarbonize sectors like maritime and aviation.

GERMAN PARLIAMENT WANTS EV SUBSIDY TO INCLUDE LOCAL CONTENT: Germany is going to adjust its electric vehicle incentive program to include local content requirements in a bid to help European manufacturers, according to a resolution paper adopted by the coalition parliamentary groups on Friday. The federal government is to present "local content criteria that comply with EU law," according to the paper, which was seen by our colleague Tom Schmidtgen.

Getting tough on trade: The groups are also jointly calling for more anti-dumping and anti-subsidy measures to protect domestic industries. While the paper does not name China directly, it calls out "geoeconomic disparities" and "one-sided dependencies regarding raw materials and products reduced."

Auto package decisions: The parliamentary groups also set a common position on the Commission's automotive package, calling for the emission target for automakers to be set at 90 percent with no required offsets.

Freezing the utility factor: The utility factor estimates the emissions from hybrids based on how much consumers use the electric motor versus the combustion engine. The Commission plans on updating the utility factor in 2027 to reflect real-world data that shows people drive on the combustion engine more frequently than expected. The German parliamentary groups are calling for the utility factor to remain

unchanged, as it would allow more hybrids to count toward automakers' emission targets.

MARITIME

EUROPE'S SHIP RECYCLING QUESTION: Environmental groups and shipowners are at odds over where Europe's aging fleet should be dismantled, with NGOs arguing Brussels should keep ships — and their valuable recyclable materials — at home, while industry wants more overseas yards approved if they meet EU environmental and safety standards.

Going abroad: Between 2019 and 2025, just 22 percent of 706 EU-owned or flagged ships were dismantled at EU facilities, representing only 5 percent of total tonnage, according to a new study by NGO Transport & Environment, seen in advance by POLITICO. Nearly half of the vessels — accounting for 66 percent of tonnage — were instead beached in India, Bangladesh and Pakistan.

Follow the steel: Up to 95 percent of a ship's weight can be recycled as high-quality scrap steel. NGOs want Europe to retain those materials and their economic value, while shipowners argue EU recognition can expand scarce capacity and encourage higher recycling standards abroad.

The India question: When the EU Ship Recycling Regulation was introduced in 2013, a number of Indian yards invested heavily to bring their facilities up to European standards, but inspections and assessments have taken years. The Commission proposed in July adding the first two Indian yards to its approved list, reopening a long-standing argument over whether compliant facilities outside Europe should be allowed to recycle EU-flagged vessels.

Keep it European: T&E argues Europe already has enough capacity. In 2020, EU yards had capacity for 2.1 million tons, compared with 1.4 million tons of EU-owned ships dismantled that year. They also identified 102 ships that switched away from an EU flag shortly before dismantling, which they say allowed owners to circumvent stricter EU rules.

Industry says yes: European Shipowners strongly welcomed the Commission's proposal to approve the two Indian yards, arguing that facilities which meet EU safety and environmental requirements should be recognised and that adding compliant non-OECD yards would expand the pool of available recycling capacity.

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

China's latest curbs on EU firms look symbolic. That could change.

Beijing's retaliation against the EU's Russia sanctions has been limited — but suggestive of how it could weaponize supply chains in future.

By Koen Verhelst · Aug 31, 2026, 06:00 am Europe/Brussels CEST

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